

ister telephoned Karat and CPI General Secretary A.B. Bardhan to inform them of his commitment to Bush on the bilateral treaty. His "take it or leave it" proposal to the Left came two days later. Such politically loaded statements are normally withdrawn from the public arena by damage control secretariats of the government. But in this case, the PMO did not offer an excuse or allege that he was misquoted. Manmohan's unapologetic position was unacceptable to the Left.

With the communists staging frequent walk-outs in Parliament, pressure on the Congress leadership was mounting. The Left began warning the Congress to pay heed to the "voices" of the Opposition through regular interactions with the media. Karat reserved his more serious threats for public rallies. If it was Jantar Mantar in Delhi one day, it was an obscure village in the backwaters of Kerala the next. Third Front hopefuls SP and TDP participated in such rallies along with their trade unions.

The Left attack was two-pronged. It distanced itself from BJP and its NDA allies by putting communalism on par with imperialism. And it jumped on the nationalist bandwagon by maintaining that the nuclear agreement would make "India subservient to US foreign policy". With a majority in Parliament against the agreement, the Congress and the Government were cornered.

In the beginning, both Manmohan and Sonia underestimated the red resistance. A five-nation joint naval exercise was launched by India in the Bay of Bengal, in which the US Navy also participated. When Delhi had signed the decade-long defence framework agreement with Washington in 2005, the Left had tried to create problems for the Congress, but Mukherjee, who was then defence minister, handled the opposition well. Besides, the Left's objections were limited, since the framework, unlike the 123 Agreement, wasn't binding for 40 years. Communist leaders organised anti-Bush road shows on the western coast for four days of the naval manoeuvres, but the situation wasn't perceived by the Left as an "absolute attempt by the Bush administration to

CAGEY COMMANDER SONIA GANDHI

"Sometimes a great deal is made in public domain of the opinions expressed by our friends, who support our coalition. But this should not alarm you. We believe it is important to listen to all points of view."

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"We are trying at every level to meet our energy requirements. That is why there is a proposal for a nuclear agreement with the US. Elements opposed to the country's progress are enemies of the country."

"We are not in favour of early elections. As the prime minister has said, the deadline is 2009. I don't think the Left is being unreasonable. It has a certain ideology. It is merely stating its views."

OCTOBER 12, 2007



SIPRA DAS